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Around the same time the PSLV lifted off, an inspector called Vijayan was ‘inquiring’ a Maldivian woman called Mariam Rasheeda who had gone to him with a request for extension of her stay. She had apparently come for medical treatment and also looking for a school admission for her friend Fauziyya Hassan’s daughter.

According to media interviews later given by Mariam, the inspector made sexual advances and, when she did not yield, kept her travel documents with him and later booked her for overstay and soon spying. This was later confirmed by a court that absolved Mariam of the charges.

The inspector, having found ISRO scientist Sasikumaran’s name in Rasheeda’s phone directory, now got a reason to question the woman on her connection with the scientist. It turned out that Mariam had contacted Sasi through a common friend, for the treatment of her daughter. Sasi, whose wife was a doctor, offered help. I later realised that he did meet Mariam a few times with his wife.

The day after the successful launch of PSLV-D2, when I returned from Sriharikota, IB and R&AW had questioned Mariam, and Sasi had given a detailed note to the LPSC director and ISRO chairman about the police having contacted him.

I felt sad for Sasi, who was my deputy in the cryogenic project, but this episode had nothing to do with my decision to quit ISRO. After all, it was a settled issue with U R Rao the previous year that I would walk soon after the first successful launch of PSLV.

On 26 October 1994, I accompanied ISRO chairman Kasturirangan to New Delhi for a felicitation by the Indian Prime Minister for our successful PSLV launch. Four days later, on 1 November 1994, I handed over my letter requesting for voluntary retirement from ISRO, to the chairman. In the three previous instances when I had offered to resign—once when Dhawan was the chairman, and twice during the last leg of U R Rao’s tenure—the chairman had thrown the paper in the dustbin and asked me to stay back. Kasturirangan did none of it—he took the letter from me.